

REMEMBERING JAMES

As we have noted, it is Paul who gives us our earliest reference to James and his leadership over the Jerusalem-based movement following the death of Jesus (Galatians 1:18–19; 2:9). Paul’s evidence here is invaluable since the author of the book of Acts only begrudgingly and obliquely acknowledges the leadership of James over the entire Jesus movement. Acts is our only early account of the history of early Christianity, and its prominent place in the New Testament, following the four gospels, ensured its dominance. It is the book of Acts that is largely responsible for the standard portrait of early Christianity in which Peter and Paul assume such a dominant role and James is largely marginalized or left out entirely. The presentation of Acts has become *the* story, even though its version of events is woefully one-sided and historically questionable. The author of Acts surely knew, but was not willing to state, that James took over the leadership of the movement after Jesus’ death. In his early chapters he never even mentions James by name and casts Peter and John, the other two “pillars,” as the undisputed leaders of Jesus’ followers, effectively blurring out James entirely. His major agenda in the book as a whole is to promote the centrality of the mission and message of the apostle Paul. Although Acts has twenty-four chapters, once Paul is introduced in [chapter 9](#) the rest of the book is wholly about Paul. Even Peter begins to drop out of the picture after chapter 12. Rather than “Acts of the Apostles” the book might better be named “The Acts of Paul.” This suppression of James is systematic and deliberate, as we shall see.

According to Mark, our earliest gospel, the townspeople at Nazareth, where Jesus grew up, are amazed at his teachings and his miracles. They say to one another: “Is this not the carpenter, the son of Mary and *brother of James and Joses and Judas and Simon*, and are not his sisters here with us?” (Mark 6:3). Most scholars are convinced that the author of the gospel of Luke, who also wrote the book of Acts, used Mark as his main source. He has some independent material, as well as the Q source (which I will explain below), but his core story of Jesus is taken from Mark. Accordingly, he edits Mark freely, based on his own emphases and agenda. Here, for example, when he relates this scene in Nazareth, based on Mark, he *omits the names of the brothers* and has the people ask, “Is not this Joseph’s son?” (Luke 4:22). His silence has nothing to do with the idea that Mary had no other children.